

MODAL AUXILIARY VERB

Modal Auxiliary Verb :

It is a combination of modal and auxiliary verbs.

Auxiliary verbs :- Those verbs which add grammatical meaning to the clause in which it appears. These are used to convey modality, voice, tense, emphasise etc. These are also called **helping verbs**. They mainly accompany the 'main verb'.

Main verb :- It is the principal verb which shows the action or state of being of the subject.

Example :- I have drunk a glass of milk.

Here, "drunk" is the main verb and "have" is an auxiliary verb.

Modal auxiliary verbs are a part of auxiliary verbs used mainly to express modality; such as obligation, offers, ability, requests, possibility, necessity, permission, etc.

The modal auxiliary verbs are: "**can, could, shall, will, may, might, must, need, dare, ought to, would, should, used to, had better**".

The primary auxiliary verbs are: "**be, do, have**".

Exception :- Here, "need, dare, ought to" can be used as the main verb; while "had better" is always followed by an infinitive and "used to" can be used as an adjective. Thus, these words are **marginal auxiliary verbs or quasi-modals**.

Example :- She could have completed her homework by now.

Here, 'could' is a modal auxiliary verb; 'have' is an auxiliary verb and 'completed' is the main verb.

Some Important general Rules :-

1. They do not have "participle or infinitive form". i.e "to-infinitive form"

Example :-

- We shall to see you tomorrow. (**incorrect**)
- We shall see you tomorrow. (**correct**)

2. They do not take "s/es" after them.

Example :-

- She cans study English. (**incorrect**)
- She can study English. (**correct**)

3. They do not take "ing-form", "past form" and "ed-form" i.e they don't change their form and are always used in the same form.

Example :-

- They musted win the match. (**incorrect**)
- They must win the match. (**correct**)

4. Modal verbs cannot be used with another modal verb :-

Example :-

- Running can might be difficult on slippery tracks. (**incorrect**)
- Running can be difficult on slippery tracks. (**correct**)

5. Their negatives are formed by adding 'not' after them and we do not use **don't, doesn't, didn't** with them.

Example :-

- I don't can go to school today. (**incorrect**)
- I can't go to School today. (**correct**)

6. Questions can be formed by changing the positions of the Subject and the Modal Verbs :-

Example :-

- Do will it be ok to go outside now? (**incorrect**)
- Will it be ok to go outside now? (**correct**)

MODAL AUXILIARY VERB (USAGE) :-**1. SHALL & WILL****RULE 1 :-**

"Shall and will" are used to express the simple future of any person (1st, 2nd or 3rd). We mainly use 'shall' with the first person i.e. "I" and "we" and 'will' with other people.

Example :-

- **Rahul will** attend a Parliamentary meeting tomorrow.
- **I shall** meet you at the cafe next Monday.

RULE 2 :-

In order to express certain situations (**compulsion / threat/ determination/ promise/ command/ willingness**), we use "will" with the first person, "shall" with other persons.

Although, in interrogative sentences, we must use only "shall" with "I" and "we".

Example :-

- Will I go to the trade fair? (**incorrect**)
- Shall we go to the trade fair? (**correct**)
- Will they go to the trade fair? (**correct**)

(a) Compulsion

- I will finish the project by tomorrow morning.
- Students shall complete their assignments by Friday.

(b) Threat

- You shall regret crossing me.
- I will lodge an FIR against the thief.

(c) Determination

- I will work day and night to finish this project on time.
- The political leader shall make use of all his sources to win this election.

(d) Promise

- I will help all the citizens in this need of hour.
- You shall be given a present if you come first.

(e) Command

- You shall switch off the light when you leave.

RULE 3 :-

"Will" and "shall" are followed by an infinitive without "to".

Example :-

- You shall to go to the market. (**incorrect**)
- You shall go to the market. (**correct**)

RULE 4 :-

Question and negatives are made without "do".

Example :-

- Will you go to market today?
- Will she not take tea?

RULE 5 :-

In imperative sentences starting with "let us/ let's", use "shall we" in the question tag.

Example :-

- Let us watch a movie, shall we?

RULE 6 :-

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In interrogative sentences, "shall" is used to make suggestions.

Example :-

- Shall we lodge a complaint?

RULE 7 :-

'Would' is used in place of "shall/will" to express a desired outcome or an expectation of what might happen in future based on hope and anticipation.

Example :-

- I hoped that she would clear the exam.
- She hoped that her friend would understand her perspective.

Note :- If a sentence starts with the past, then it will continue to be in the past. Thus, "would/should" is used in such cases.

Exception :- In case of universal truth, idiom and phrase, habitual action, general fact; this rule is not applicable.

Example :-

- We were told that everything **is** impermanent and changing.

2. CAN & COULD

"Can" is used to express :- power, ability, possibility, make request, give permission, certainty, doubt etc.

"Could" is used to express :- ability, possibility, make request.

RULE 8 :- Use of "can" :-

(a) Structure of sentences using "can"
(Subject + can + main verb)

Note : Here, 'main verb' is always used as bare infinitive (i.e. without 'to').

Example :-

- I can play football.

(b) To express power, ability or capacity.

Example :-

- You can do hard work and get a government job.
- Can you read French novels?

(c) To make friendly requests or give permission.

Example :-

- Can you please make a cup of coffee for the guests?
- You can go ahead and take the day off if you need to.

(d) For conceptual possibility.

Example :-

- Every gas can expand.
- It can rain later.

(e) For certainty/ likelihood.

Example :-

- It can be challenging to learn a new language.
- That can't be the right answer.

(f) For expressing doubt/ disbelief.

Example :-

- He can't be serious about quitting his job.
- She can't have forgotten her keys again.

RULE 9 :- Use of "could":-

(a) Structure of sentence using "could":-
(Subject + could + main verb)

Note :- Here, 'main verb' is always used as a bare infinitive (i.e. without 'to').

Example :-

- My grandfather could cook for himself.

(b) To express past ability & possibility.

Example :-

- I could do skipping when I was 5 years old.
- Could you comprehend what your tour guide told you?
- People could not listen to the leader as the mike was not working properly.

(c) To make a formal request.

Example :-

- Could you assist me in arranging the meeting?
- Could I talk to the branch manager?

(d) To express remote possibility.

Example :-

- There could be a snake in your bathroom.

(e) To express hypothetical situations.

Example :-

- If he studied harder, he could pass the exam.
- I could help you if I had more time.

(f) To express a suggestion/ offer.

Example :-

- I could give you a ride to the airport if you need one.
- You could ask for help if you're feeling overwhelmed with your workload.

Note :- (a) We never use "can/could" and "be able to" together as both of them have the same meaning. Using both of them together will make the sentence superfluous.

(b) We use "to" with "be able", which states that it takes an infinitive verb and not a modal auxiliary verb.

Example :-

- I couldn't was able to call her yesterday. (**incorrect**)
- I couldn't call her yesterday. (**correct**)
- I was not able to call her yesterday. (**correct**)

3. MAY, MIGHT & MUST

RULE 10 :-

Although both 'may' and 'might' express possibility; 'may' implies better likelihood of something happening than using 'might' in the sentence.

Example :-

- It may rain today.
- She might clear the UPSC exam as she has been a topper throughout her academics yet I do not have much expectation.

RULE 11 :-

For unreal situations, we mostly use 'might'.

Example :-

- There might be a ghost inside the suitcase.

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RULE 12 :-

To speak about **past actions/events**, we use 'may have' or 'might have'.

Example :-

- She might have forgotten about the meeting.
- Kamlesh is late today. She may have missed her train.

RULE 13 :-

To **express wishes and desires in an optative sentence**, we use "may".

Example :-

- May your daughter live happily ever after.

RULE 14 :-

If the principal clause is in present tense and the subordinate clause starts with 'that/ so that/ in order that' denoting purpose then we use "may" in the subordinate clause.

Example :-

- I hope that she may succeed in her career.

RULE 15 :-

"May" is used as an alternative to "can" when we ask, give or refuse permission which is quite formal.

Example :-

- Sir, may I leave early today?
- May I come in?

Note :- "May" is generally used for requests with the first person. With 'you', "could" is mostly used.

Example :-

- Could you keep quiet?

RULE 16 :-

To mean that you should do something because there is no better alternative, we use "may/might" with "as well".

Example :-

- Since the restaurant is fully booked, we may as well cook dinner at home.

RULE 17 :-

"Must" is used for greater possibility.

Example :-

- She travels in aeroplane and shops in malls, she must be a working woman.
- She must be the new employee; I haven't seen her before.

RULE 18 :-

We never use "possibly/likely" with "may" as that makes the sentence superfluous.

Example :-

- He may possibly arrange a birthday party for his wife. (**Incorrect**)
- He may arrange a birthday party for his wife. (**Correct**)
- He is likely to arrange a birthday party for his wife. (**Correct**)

RULE 19 :-

"Must" shows fixed determination/compulsion/duty.

Example :-

- Ram must liberate Sita. (**fixed determination**)
- Candidates must bring a mask and sanitizer. (**compulsion**)
- The Indian Prime Minister must take measures to eradicate unemployment from the country. (**duty**)

RULE 20 :-

We often use "may" to accept a different view or opinion, especially with *well*, and/or followed by "*but I*".

Example :-

- I may be wrong but I am going to complete this task alone.

RULE 21 :-

We can use “*might*” to give advice or make a suggestion sound more polite or less direct, especially when used together with *like*, *prefer* or *want*.

Example :-

- You might like to try our new grammar book.

4. NEED & DARE :**RULE 22 :-**

‘Need’ expresses requirement while ‘dare’ expresses courage.

Example :-

- She need not finish her homework.
- Children dare not make noise in the classroom.

Here, both ‘need’ and ‘dare’ are acting as modal auxiliary verbs.

RULE 23 :-

Both “Need” and “Dare” can be used as ‘main verb’ or as ‘modal’.

Example :-

- I need you. (**main verb**)
- I need not come everyday. (**modal auxiliary**)
- Children did not dare to go into that haunted cottage. (**main verb**)
- How dare you break the window glass? (**modal**)

RULE 24 :-

“Dare” and “Need” does not change form (-s/es) with third person singular when used as a modal but can change the form when used as a main verb.

Example :-

- John dares not tell his wife about liking his colleague. (**Incorrect** because ‘dare’ is a modal here)
John dare not tell his wife about liking his colleague. (**Correct**)
- Your father **dares** me to go out at night. (**Correct** because ‘dare’ is acting as the main verb here.)
- He **needs** to help his father in business. (**Correct** because ‘need’ is acting as the main verb here.)
- She need not trust anybody. (**Correct** because ‘need’ is a modal here)

RULE 25 :-

If the sentence is positive, we mainly use ‘to + V₁’ after need and dare.

Example :-

- You need to work hard.
- Gamblers will not dare to come here again.

RULE 26 :-

If “need/dare” are used in negative sentences, ‘not’ is followed by a bare infinitive i.e. only ‘V₁’ is used.

Example :-

- Mohan need not play basketball.
- He dare not cheat his business partners.

RULE 27 :-

“Need” modal can be used with ‘none/ nothing/ no one’ but not with ‘don’t/ doesn’t/ didn’t’.

Example :-

- Nothing need be done now.
- No one need know you are working for IB if you don’t tell them.
- Do we need discuss the problem? (**Incorrect**)
- Need we discuss the problem? (**Correct**)

RULE 28 :-

"Need" is used as the main verb in affirmative sentences to show obligation.

Example :-

- I need to submit the report by the end of the day.
- They need to attend the meeting tomorrow.

RULE 29 :-

We can use "Need" to show no-obligation or lack of necessity also. It is most common in negative sentences.

Example :-

- You needn't buy many books, this book is sufficient for exam purposes. ('Need' as a semi-modal to show lack of necessity)
- You don't need to worry about the details; I'll take care of it. ('Need' as the main verb to show lack of necessity)

5. OUGHT TO :

It is used both as a modal and main verb i.e. it does not change form like modal verbs but has 'to' with it unlike modals.

Example :-

- You ought to call your parents.

RULE 30 :-

It shows moral obligation/duty/desired/likely.

Example :-

- We ought to respect our country. (**duty**)
- They ought to have more stationery shops in the city. (**desired**)
- The concert ought to take only two hours. So, we will be home by 11pm.

RULE 31 :-

"Ought to" cannot be used with other modal verbs.

Example :-

- Doctors ought to can give proper medication. (**Incorrect**)
- Doctors ought to give proper medication. (**Correct**)

RULE 32 :-

It can be made negative by adding 'not' between 'ought' and 'to' i.e. ought not to.

Example :-

- I ought not to eat junk food.

RULE 33 :-

Words such as 'don't, didn't, doesn't' are not used with 'ought to'.

Example :-

- I don't ought to smoke. (**Incorrect**)
- I ought not to smoke. (**Correct**)

6. WOULD :

Would is the past form of 'will'.

RULE 34 :-

To express past beliefs about the future, would is used. i.e to tell about the future in the past.

Example :-

- I thought she would be late, so I gave a project to someone else.
- When I failed my 12th exam, I thought I would never recover from that failure.

RULE 35 :-

For expressing past habits, we use 'would'.

Example :-

- I would go to school by bus.

For past routine action, we use '**would, used to or simple past**'.

Example :-

- I used to go to school by bus.

RULE 36 :-

If would is used with rather, it shows preference/choice.

Example :-

- She would rather die than beg.

RULE 37 :-

If the sentence is in the past, it will continue to be in the past.

Example :-

- They hoped that he would survive.

RULE 38 :-

To express a wish in imaginative sentences, 'would' is used with 'were', not 'was'.

Example :-

- If I were a bird, I would fly.

RULE 39 :-

Used to express polite requests in interrogative sentences.

Example :-

- Would you switch on the fan?
- Would you open the door?

RULE 40 :-

Used as past of 'will' when sentence is changed from direct to indirect.

Example :-

- She said, "I will go to the market". (**Direct**)
- She said that she would go to the market. (**Indirect**)

RULE 41 :-

We often use 'would' with verbs such as advice, imagine, recommend, say, suggest and think

Example :-

- I would advise you to keep working on your grammar.
- I would recommend that you try the pinnacle test series.

RULE 42 :-

Used to express **polite expressions and softening statements**.

Example :-

- I would like to discuss the proposal with you.
- I would think that it's better to wait.

RULE 43 :-

Used to make **offers and suggestions**.

Example :-

- Would you like some help with that?
- I would suggest trying the new restaurant downtown.

RULE 44 :-

Used to express **preferences or desires**.

Example :-

- I would prefer tea instead of coffee.

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7. SHOULD :

RULE 45 :-

To give suggestions/advice/recommendation.

Example :-

- You look beautiful. You should try in Bollywood.
- This restaurant has awesome food. You should try it once.

RULE 46 :-

To express a situation that is likely to happen in the present/future.

Example :-

- She should have the letter by now. I sent it two weeks ago.
- India should win the match. They have practiced a lot during lockdown.

RULE 47 :-

'Should + have' is used to express moral obligation that did not happen.

Example :-

- You should have studied hard to become a topper.
- Ram should have discussed the transfer with his wife before accepting the job offer.

RULE 48 :-

To express that the subject is not acting sensibly in case of obligation.

Example :-

- Children should be wearing helmets and knee pads while skating. (Meaning: At present, children are not wearing helmets and knee pads while skating.)
- He should be practicing for the match. (Meaning: He is not practicing at the moment.)

8. USED TO :

RULE 49 :-

To express past habit or state.

Example :-

- I used to go to school by bicycle.
- We used to live in Maharashtra.

RULE 50 :-

For negative sentences; we use: "didn't + use + to".

Example :-

- He didn't use to work properly.

RULE 51 :-

"Used to" is the same for all the subjects: I/We/They/He/She etc.

Example :-

- We used to go jogging in the evening.
- She used to work in MNC before marriage.

RULE 52 :-

For past routine action, we can use 'would, used to or simple past'.

Example :-

- I used to go to school by bus.
- I would go to America when I was working.
- The family gathered for dinner every night.

RULE 53 :-

We use "be + used to + ing form" to express our familiarity with a place/activity.

Example :-

- I am used to studying late at night during exam days.
- My husband is used to watching the IPL.

RULE 54 :-

While making Question tags after "Used to", we use "Did/Didn't".

Example :-

- He used to be your teacher, didn't he?

9. HAD BETTER :**RULE 55 :-**

We use 'had better' for hope / warning.

Example :-

- The Indian team had better win the world cup. (**Hope**)
- You had better keep quiet. (**Warning**)

RULE 56 :-

For specific advice, it is followed by a bare infinitive.

Example :-

- It is getting late. You had better leave the office now or you will miss the last train.

RULE 57 :-

"had better +...+ or" to show negative results of not following your advice.

Example :-

- You had better take medication or you will not recuperate.
- He had better apply sunscreen or he will get tanning.

Practice Exercise

Spot the Error :-

Directions : In these questions, read each sentence to find out whether there is any error in the Modal Auxiliaries used or not.

- Q.1.** (a) They mighted /(b) enjoy the concert /(c) last night /(d) no error.
- Q.2.** (a) Doctors ought to /(b) can give /(c) proper medication /(d) no error.
- Q.3.** (a) I will completes the /(b) assignment before /(c) the deadline. /(d) no error.
- Q.4.** (a) You had better /(b) finish that report /(c) or your boss will not be upset. /(d) no error.
- Q.5.** (a) May your daughter /(b) live happily /(c) ever after /(d) no error.
- Q.6.** (a) She should attend the /(b) conference tomorrow if /(c) her schedule allows /(d) no error.
- Q.7.** (a) You should better /(b) leave the /(c) office now /(d) no error.
- Q.8.** (a) Nothing needs /(b) ought to be /(c) done for now /(d) no error.
- Q.9.** (a) I couldn't /(b) be able to call /(c) her yesterday /(d) no error.
- Q.10.** (a) It is getting late, you /(b) would better leave the office now /(c) or you will miss the last train /(d) no error.
- Q.11.** (a) He needs not work hard /(b) because he is rich enough /(c) to live a lavish life. /(d) no error.
- Q.12.** (a) He used to be /(b) your teacher, /(c) usedn't he? /(d) no error.
- Q.13.** (a) We could /(b) leave for the airport soon/(c) to avoid traffic /(d) no error.

- Q.14. (a) I should like /(b) to discuss the /(c) proposal with you /(d) no error.
- Q.15. (a) I can suggest trying /(b) the new /(c) restaurant downtown/(d) no error.
- Q.16. (a) She said that /(b) she will go /(c) to the market /(d) no error.
- Q.17. (a) I can solve this /(b) math problem without /(c) any difficulty /(d) no error.
- Q.18. (a) You should consult /(b) a doctor if your /(c) symptoms persist /(d) no error.
- Q.19. (a) Employees can attend /(b) the mandatory /(c) training session /(d) no error.
- Q.20. (a) Last year, I can speak only a /(b) few words in Spanish, /(c) but now I can hold a conversation /(d) no error.

Fill in the Blanks with the Appropriate “Modals” :-

- Q.1. Children _____ not go to the terrace at night.
- Q.2. He _____ read a book while watching TV during his school days.
- Q.3. He _____ pass this time as he has worked satisfactorily hard.
- Q.4. She said that she _____ prepare dinner herself.
- Q.5. _____ his soul rest in peace.
- Q.6. They _____ to play badminton every day when they were in the college.
- Q.7. You _____ to go to Mumbai tomorrow to attend the seminar
- Q.8. If you stayed here, you _____ not face the problem.
- Q.9. _____ he had worked hard, he would have passed.
- Q.10. _____ you please help me lift this bag ?
- Q.11. You _____ to submit your file to the authorities within a week.
- Q.12. There. _____ be a school at this place
- Q.13. Nothing _____ be done under such circumstances.
- Q.14. Had you made one more effort you _____ have won the race.
- Q.15. Work hard lest you _____ fail.

Answers With Explanation :-

Spot the Error

- Sol.1.(a) Replace “mighted” with “might”. Modals are always used in the same form and never take s/es, ing or ed with them.
- Sol.2.(b) Remove “can” from part (b). Two modals can’t be used together.
- Sol.3.(a) Replace “completes” with “complete”. The verb that follows modal verbs must be in its base form.
- Sol.4.(c) Remove “not” after will. Here, the sentence gives the meaning that not finishing the report will make the boss upset.
- Sol.5.(d) no error.
- Sol.6.(a) Replace “should” with “might”. As “might” shows less possibility.

- Sol.7.(a)** Replace "should" with "had". To show urgency or importance "had better" is used.
- Sol.8.(b)** Remove "ought" from part (b). Here, need to be means there is no requirement or obligation for any action.
- Sol.9.(b)** Remove "be able to" from part (b). As can/could is used to show ability, using 'able' with 'could' is superfluous.
- Sol.10.(b)** Replace "would" with "had". To show urgency or importance "had better" is used.
- Sol.11.(a)** Replace "needs" with "need".
- Sol.12.(c)** Replace "usedn't" with "didn't". In the sentence with modal used to, question tag "didn't" is used.
- Sol.13.(a)** Replace "would" with "should". For mild obligations, "should" is used.
- Sol.14.(a)** Replace "should" with "would". "Would" is used to form polite expressions.
- Sol.15.(a)** Replace "can" with "would". "Would" is used to make offers or suggestions.
- Sol.16.(a)** Replace "will" with "would". In indirect speech, use the past form of "will".
- Sol.17.(d)** no error.
- Sol.18.(d)** no error.
- Sol.19.(a)** Replace "can" with "must". To show compulsion, "must" is used.
- Sol.20.(a)** Replace "can" with "could". For past abilities, "could" is used.

Fill in the Blanks

- Sol.1.** Should
- Sol.2.** Would
- Sol.3.** May
- Sol.4.** Would
- Sol.5.** May
- Sol.6.** Used
- Sol.7.** Will Have
- Sol.8.** Would
- Sol.9.** Should
- Sol.10.** Could
- Sol.11.** Have
- Sol.12.** Used to
- Sol.13.** Can
- Sol.14.** Would
- Sol.15.** Should

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